

Hippopotamus amphibius

Common Hippopotamus



Location Africa

Length 9½–16 ft
(2.9–5.1 m)Tail 16–22 in
(40–56 cm)Weight 1–4¼ tons
(1–4.5 tonnes)

Social unit Individual

Status Vulnerable



Despite its massive bulk, the common hippopotamus walks underwater with grace, and trots with surprising rapidity on land on its short legs. A truly amphibious mammal, its skin has a thin outer layer (epidermis), which dries out easily and is sensitive to the bites of pests such as flies. Despite specialized mucus-producing skin glands, the hide soon cracks unless moistened regularly in water or mud. However, the skin's

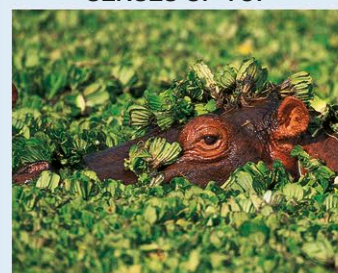
inner layer (dermis) is up to 1½ in (3.5 cm) thick and formed of a dense mat of fibers that provides great strength. The hippopotamus's main diet is grass, grazed at night, although they have been observed eating small animals or scavenging. The dominant male mates with females in his territory, and the usually single calf is born, generally underwater, after a gestation of 240 days—short for such

a large mammal. The mother is fiercely protective, and the calf has few natural predators apart from big cats and hyenas. Hippopotamuses have been known to attack humans, if they feel threatened.

BUOYANCY

The density of the hippopotamus's body is slightly greater than that of water, so it sinks gently and can walk light footed along the bottom. However, if it keeps its lungs well inflated when breathing at the surface, the extra air reduces this density and it can stay afloat with minimal effort.

SENSES UP TOP



The hippopotamus's nostrils, eyes, and ears are all on top of its head, so it can be almost totally submerged yet breathe easily and remain receptive to its surroundings. The nostrils and ears are closed to water entry when diving.

TEMPORARY HERDS

During the dry season, hippopotamuses must wander to find grazing. Instead of each animal returning to its home area by day, some use a nearby pool as a short-term "stop-over" wallow, thereby extending its grazing range. This leads to large gatherings at certain pools, but these lack long-term social or territorial structures.



MOTHER AND CALVES

Calves remain with their mothers after weaning (usually 10–12 months) until about 5 months.

*Choeropsis liberiensis*

Pygmy hippopotamus



Location W. Africa

Length 5–5¾ ft
(1.5–1.75 m)Tail 8 in
(20 cm)Weight 350–595 lb
(160–270 kg)

Social unit Individual

Status Endangered



Only one-fifth the weight of its huge cousin (above), the pygmy hippopotamus has a relatively small, less angular head and narrower feet with fewer webbed toes, as adaptations for spending more time on land. It also feeds on a wider variety of plant materials, including shrubs, ferns, and fruit. Pygmy hippopotamuses are usually solitary; although their home ranges overlap, there seems to be little fighting for territory or other form of interaction.

They forage at night, following well-worn trails, and spend the day hidden in swamps or sometimes in a riverbank den enlarged from the burrow of some other animal. After a gestation period of 6 months, the single calf is born, in water or in the den. The calf risks falling prey to a crocodile or python, but adults have few predators except for leopards

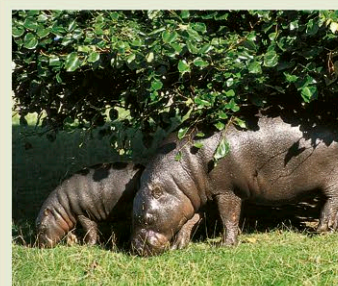
and humans. Captive pygmy hippopotamuses have lived longer than many hippopotamuses: 55 compared to about 45 years.

LAND-BASED FORAGER

A pygmy hippopotamus's squat, narrow-fronted form is suited to pushing head down through dense forest vegetation during night-foraging on land.



CONSERVATION



Evidence suggests that the pygmy hippopotamus has always been rare. It survives in dense forests and marshes in Liberia and neighboring West African countries. Despite legal protection, its population is declining due to habitat loss and being hunted for bushmeat. The flesh of this animal is said to resemble pork, yet genetic studies indicate that hippopotamuses are more closely related to whales than to pigs.